

in the Google Play store, you may not know that some of those permissions are impacting your privacy more severely than you realise.

While permissions are taking control of your device with or without your knowledge, third party trackers also compromise your privacy by stealthily collecting data without your consent. And the worst part is that you have no clue as to how many trackers you have in your Android app.

To view the permissions for an Android app and the trackers in it, use Exodus Privacy.

Exodus Privacy is an Android app that has been created and maintained by a French non-profit organisation. While the app is not capable of any analysis, it will fetch reports from the Exodus Platform for the apps that are installed in your device.

These reports are auto-generated by using the static analysis method and, currently, the Exodus platform contains 58,392 reports. Each report gives you information about the number of trackers and permissions.

Permissions are evaluated using the three levels of Google Permission Classification. These are 'Normal', 'Signature' and 'Dangerous'. We should be concerned about the 'Dangerous' level because such permissions can access the user's private and other stored sensitive data.

Trackers are also listed in this app. When you click on a tracker, you will be taken to a page which shows you the other Android apps that have that particular tracker. This can be really useful to know if the same tracker has been used in the other apps that you have installed.

In addition, the reports will contain information such as 'Fingerprint' and other geographical details about the app publisher such as 'Country', 'State' and 'Locality'.

Net Guard

Most Android apps need network access to function properly, but offline

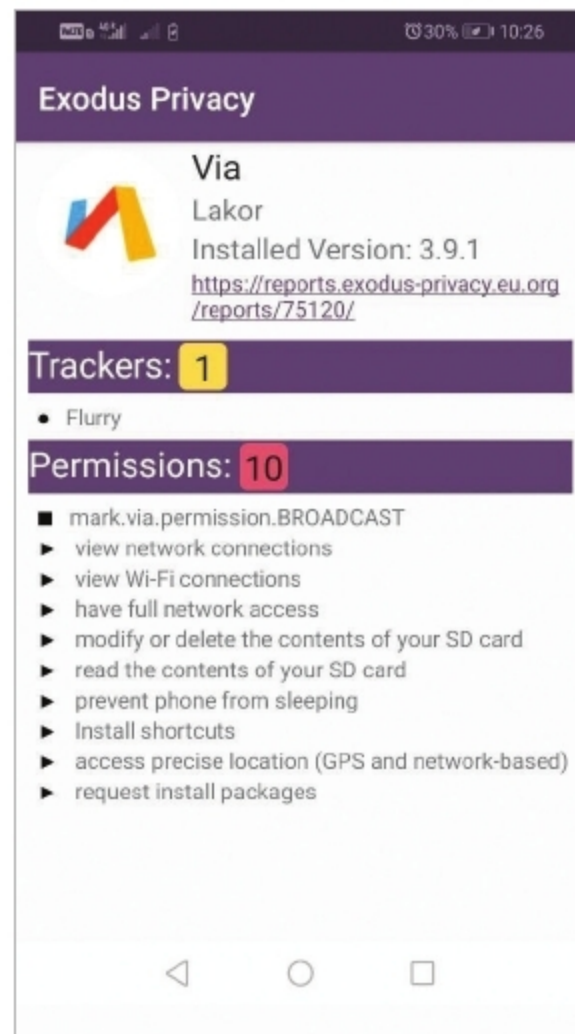


Figure 2: Exodus Privacy

apps don't need this to operate. Yet some of these offline apps continue to run in the background and use network access for some reason or the other. As a result, your battery gets drained very quickly and the data plan on your phone gets exhausted faster than you think.

Net Guard solves this problem by blocking the network access to selected apps. Net Guard will only block the outgoing traffic from apps, not what's incoming.

The Net Guard main window displays all the installed apps. For every app you will see the 'mobile network' icon and the 'Wi-Fi' icon. When they are both green, it means that Net Guard will allow the app to have network access via the mobile network and Wi-Fi. Alternatively, you can enable any one of them; for example, you can allow the app to use the Internet only via the mobile network by clicking on the 'Mobile network' icon to turn it green while the 'Wi-Fi' icon is red.

When both the 'Mobile network' and 'Wi-Fi' icons are red, the app's outgoing traffic is blocked.

Also, when 'Lockdown' mode is

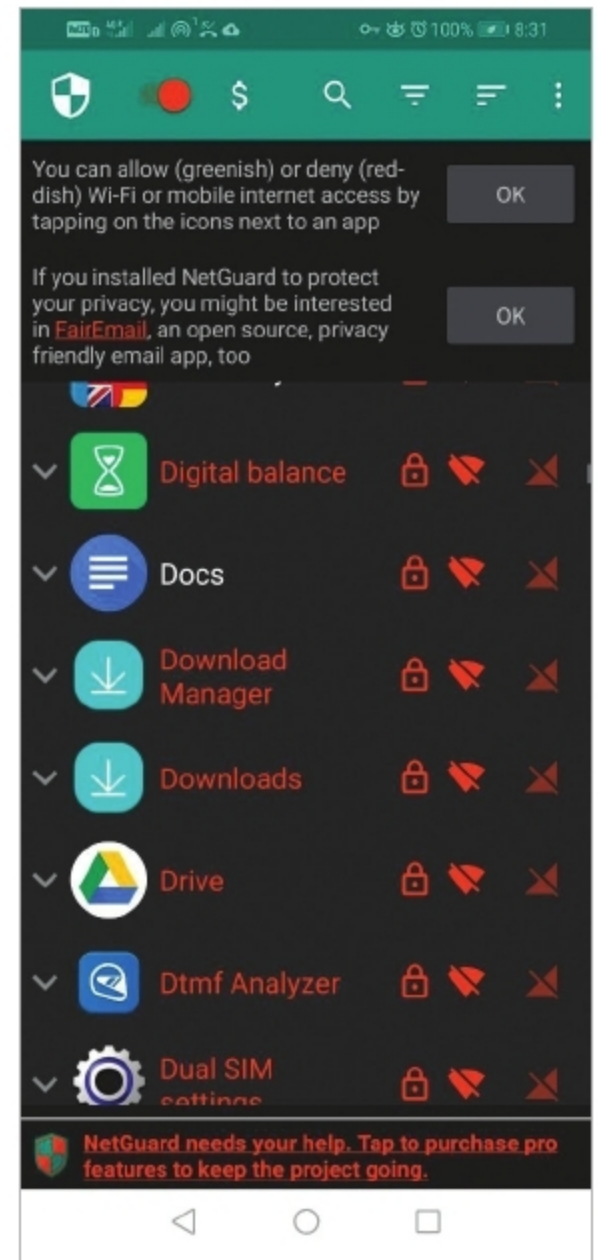


Figure 3: Net Guard

enabled, it will block the network access for all apps except those that are configured to have network access in the 'Lockdown' mode too. This is useful when you have very little battery and your data plan is about to expire.

Net Guard can also block network access to the system apps, but please be cautious about this because sometimes, when the user blocks Internet access to some critical system apps, it could result in a malfunction of other apps.

xBrowserSync

xBrowserSync is a free and open source service that helps to sync bookmarks across your devices. Most of the sync services require you to sign up and keep your data with them.

xBrowserSync is an anonymous and secure service, for which you need not sign up. To use this service you need to know your sync ID and have a strong password for it.